



Article by AFEDEV

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AFEDEV Launches Nigeria's Wheelchair American Football Initiative: A New Era of Inclusive Sport Begins

Lagos, Nigeria

In a landmark step toward building one of Africa's most inclusive sports ecosystems, AFEDEV has officially launched its **Wheelchair American Football Development Program**, bringing together athletes, coaches, volunteers, and community members for what marks the beginning of an exciting new chapter in adaptive sport.

The inaugural session attracted an encouraging turnout, demonstrating the growing interest in creating sporting opportunities for persons with disabilities while reinforcing AFEDEV's belief that talent, determination, and leadership are not defined by physical ability.

This initiative forms part of AFEDEV's long-term commitment to ensuring that American football becomes a sport where every individual has the opportunity to participate, develop, compete, and thrive.

More Than Football

For AFEDEV, Wheelchair American Football represents more than the introduction of a new sporting discipline.

It represents a commitment to dignity, inclusion, opportunity, and equal access.

The program has been designed to provide structured athlete development, coaching, education, competition, leadership opportunities, and community engagement for athletes with physical disabilities.

By creating this platform, AFEDEV aims to remove barriers that have historically limited participation in emerging sports while demonstrating that disability should never prevent individuals from pursuing excellence.

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Building the Future of Adaptive American Football

The Wheelchair American Football Initiative is the first phase of AFEDEV's broader Adaptive Sports Development Programme.

The long-term vision includes:

- National athlete recruitment and talent identification.
- Regional training hubs.
- Coach education and certification.
- Wheelchair Flag Football development.
- Wheelchair Tackle Football exhibitions.
- National competitions.
- Athlete scholarships.
- International exchanges and showcase opportunities.
- Partnerships with rehabilitation centres, hospitals, schools, and disability organizations.

The initiative also seeks to inspire greater participation by creating an environment where athletes can develop both on and off the field through education, leadership, and personal growth.

A Strong First Step

The inaugural training session exceeded expectations with enthusiastic participation from athletes eager to explore the sport.

Participants experienced introductory football activities adapted specifically for wheelchair users while engaging with coaches and volunteers committed to building a safe, welcoming, and empowering environment.

The energy, enthusiasm, and determination displayed during the first session reaffirmed AFEDEV's conviction that adaptive American football has enormous potential for growth across Nigeria and Africa.

While this marks only the beginning, the early response demonstrates the appetite for inclusive sporting opportunities and the possibility of building a sustainable adaptive football movement.



A Vision Beyond Competition

AFEDEV's adaptive sports strategy extends beyond the playing field.

The organization is committed to developing a complete ecosystem that supports athletes through:

- Health and wellness programs.
- Athlete insurance initiatives.
- Leadership development.
- Educational opportunities.
- Career transition support.
- Community engagement.
- Technical training.
- High-performance athlete development.

The ultimate goal is to create opportunities that positively impact lives while promoting inclusion, independence, confidence, and excellence.

Invitation to Partners

AFEDEV recognizes that building a sustainable adaptive football ecosystem requires collaboration.

The organization welcomes partnerships with:

- Government agencies.
- Disability advocacy organizations.
- Rehabilitation centres.
- Healthcare providers.
- Educational institutions.
- Corporate organizations.
- Philanthropic foundations.
- International sports bodies.
- Volunteers and community leaders.

Together, these partnerships will help expand opportunities for athletes with disabilities and establish Nigeria as a leader in adaptive American football development.

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Looking Ahead

The successful launch of the Wheelchair American Football Initiative represents the first milestone in an ambitious long-term vision.

Over the coming months, AFEDEV plans to expand athlete recruitment, develop coaching programmes, organize exhibition events, strengthen strategic partnerships, and lay the foundation for structured adaptive football competitions.

As participation grows, the organization aims to establish one of Africa's first comprehensive adaptive American football ecosystems, demonstrating that inclusion and excellence can advance together.

A Message from AFEDEV

"At AFEDEV, we believe that ability is not defined by physical limitations but by determination, courage, and opportunity. Every athlete deserves the chance to discover their potential, and we are committed to building pathways where everyone can participate, compete, and lead. Today we celebrate the beginning of a movement that will inspire generations to come."